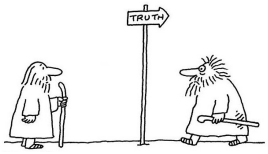
Philosophy



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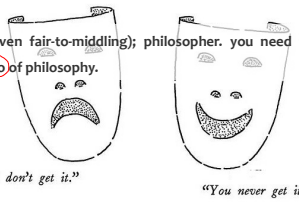
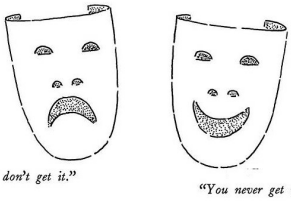
Glossary of Basic Philosophy Terms

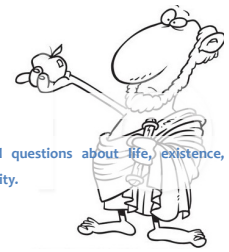
To be a really great; (or even fair-to-middling); philosopher. you need to understand some of the lingo of philosophy.





Some basic terms in philosophy include

Philosophy:



Love of wisdom. (etymology).

Philosophy is the study of fundamental questions about life, existence, knowledge, morality, and the nature of reality.

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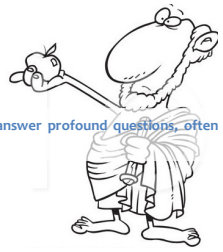
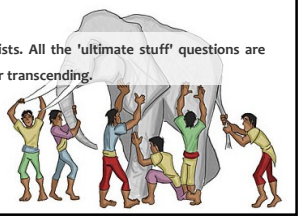
It involves thinking deeply and critically about these topics to better understand the world and our place in it.



Philosophers explore big ideas and seek to answer profound questions, often through careful reasoning and discussion.)

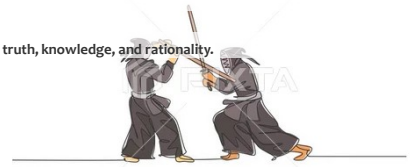
Metaphysics:

The study of being, or what really exists. All the 'ultimate stuff' questions are metaphysical ones. Meta means after or transcending.



Epistemology:

The study of belief, truth, knowledge, and rationality.



The study of knowledge, including how we acquire, justify, and understand it.

In simple terms, epistemology is concerned with questions like:

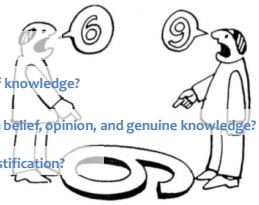
What is knowledge?

How do we know what we know?

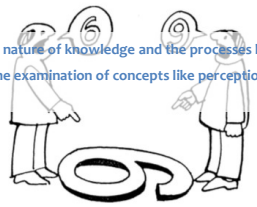
What are the sources and limits of knowledge?

How do we differentiate between belief, opinion, and genuine knowledge?

What is the nature of truth and justification?



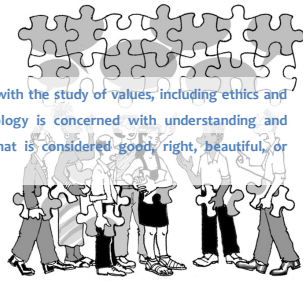
Epistemology seeks to understand the nature of knowledge and the processes by which we gain knowledge, including the examination of concepts like perception, reason, evidence, and belief.



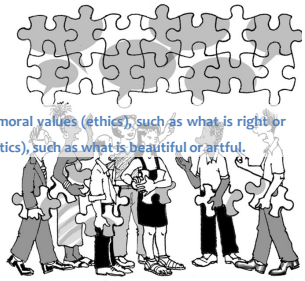
It plays a fundamental role in helping us critically assess what we can confidently claim to know and how we can validate our beliefs and understand the world.

Axiology:

A branch of philosophy that deals with the study of values, including ethics and aesthetics. In simple terms, axiology is concerned with understanding and evaluating concepts related to what is considered good, right, beautiful, or valuable in various aspects of life.



It encompasses the exploration of moral values (ethics), such as what is right or wrong, and aesthetic values (aesthetics), such as what is beautiful or artful.



Axiology helps us examine and make judgments about the principles and ideals that guide our choices and preferences in the realms of ethics and aesthetics.

Ethics:

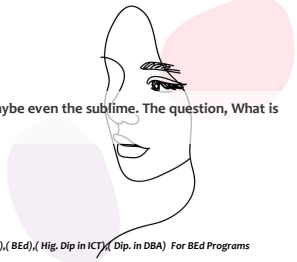
The study of good and evil, right and wrong, rules and virtues, character and vice, success and happiness.

Ethics has lots of sub-areas, including:

- Business ethics: What is it okay to do?
- Legal ethics: Who is it okay to sue?
- Medical ethics: When is it okay to clone?
- Techno ethics: Why is it okay to tap a phone?

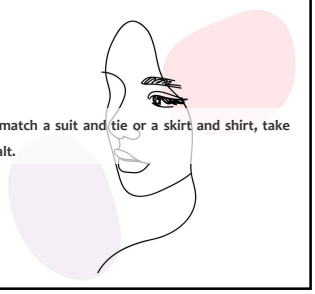
Aesthetics:

The study of beauty, ugliness, and maybe even the sublime. The question, What is art?, is an aesthetical one.



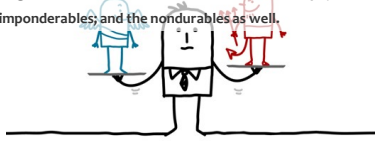
Meta-aesthetics tip:

If a theoretical aesthetician can't match a suit and tie or a skirt and shirt, take anything they say with a grain of salt.



Wisdom:

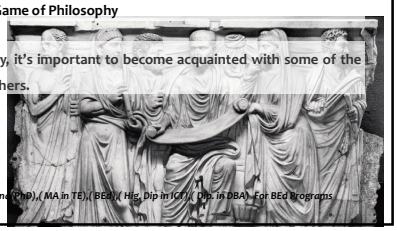
Practical insight for living. What is life? Do rocks have souls? Philosophy is all about pondering life's imponderables, and the nondurables as well.



If you're interested in philosophy (the ancient love of wisdom), it helps to know about a few of those who have gone before you, some of the issues perennially debated, and some of the terms philosophers use.

Big Names in the Ancient Game of Philosophy

If you're into philosophy, it's important to become acquainted with some of the early founding philosophers.



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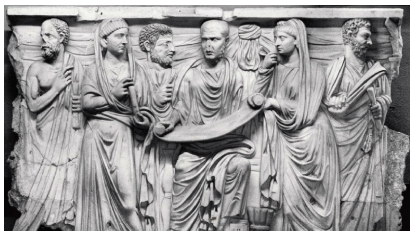
This list contains the big names and big thinkers of ancient times:

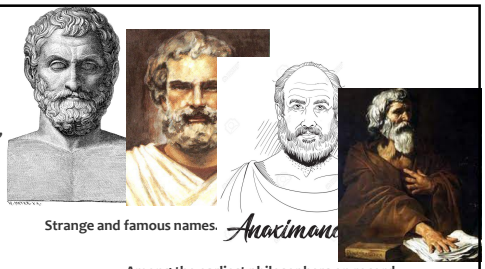


Presocratics

Anaximines,

Anaxamander,

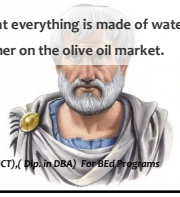
Anaxagoras.



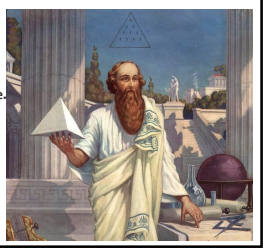
Strange and famous names.

Among the earliest philosophers on record.

Costarring such luminaries as Thales, who believed that everything is made of water, once almost drowned, and got rich from getting a corner on the olive oil market.

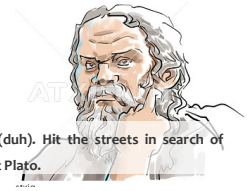


The Presocratics did speculative protoscience.



Of course, they didn't know they were Presocratics. But we do.

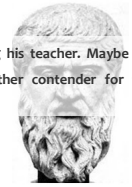
Socrates:



Did philosophy using The Socratic Method (duh). Hit the streets in search of wisdom. Executed by popular demand. Taught Plato.

Plato:

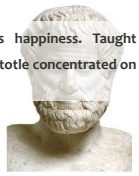
Plato
428-348 B.C.



Hung around with Socrates. Wrote dialogues featuring his teacher. Maybe the most famous philosopher of all time. Taught the other contender for this accolade, Aristotle.

Aristotle:

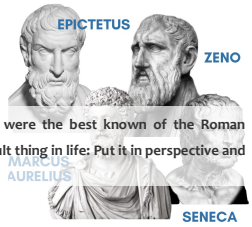
Aristotle
384-322 B.C.



Student of Plato. Codified logic. Said everyone seeks happiness. Taught Alexander the Great. Plato emphasized the next world; Aristotle concentrated on this one.

The Stoics:

Seneca, Epictetus, and Marcus Aurelius were the best known of the Roman Stoics. Main advice for handling any difficult thing in life: Put it in perspective and get over it.



Philosophy Students' Great Questions

The point of philosophy is to ponder the questions that life presents.

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Students of philosophy (and, perhaps, students of life) have raised and will continue to raise some of philosophy's greatest questions:

Why?

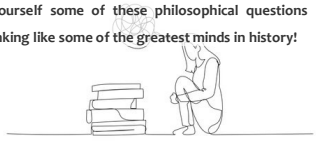
What?

Will this be on the test?

Questions that Philosophy Raises

The problems posed by the great philosophers can enhance your experience of the world.

You've probably even asked yourself some of these philosophical questions without realizing that you're thinking like some of the greatest minds in history!



Here's a sampling of some of the questions always under consideration in philosophy:

Can we really ever know anything?

What is the good in life?

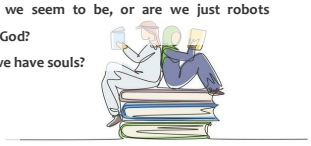
Are we actually free, as we seem to be, or are we just robots programmed by nature or God?

Are we just bodies, or do we have souls?

Do we survive death?

Is there a God?

Does life have meaning?



Socrates, Plato, and Aristotle:

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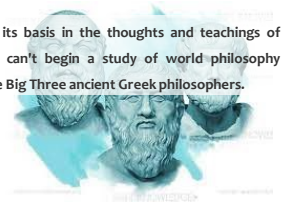
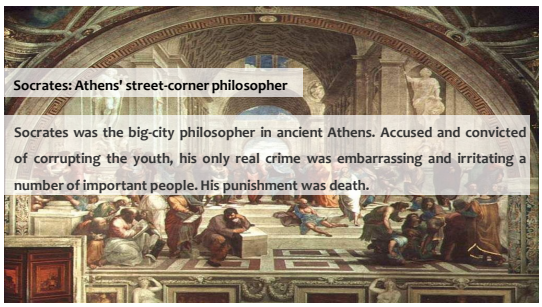
The Big Three in Greek Philosophy

Much of Western philosophy finds its basis in the thoughts and teachings of Socrates, Plato, and Aristotle. You can't begin a study of world philosophy without talking about these guys: the Big Three ancient Greek philosophers.

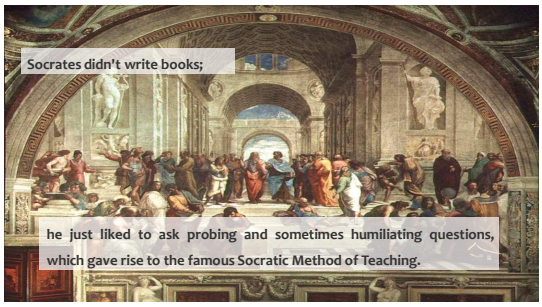




Socrates: Athens' street-corner philosopher

Socrates was the big-city philosopher in ancient Athens. Accused and convicted of corrupting the youth, his only real crime was embarrassing and irritating a number of important people. His punishment was death.

Famous quote: "The unexamined life is not worth living."



Socrates didn't write books;

he just liked to ask probing and sometimes humiliating questions, which gave rise to the famous Socratic Method of Teaching.

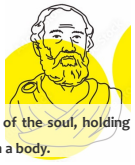
This street-corner philosopher made a career of deflating pompous windbags.

Plato: The philosopher who would be king

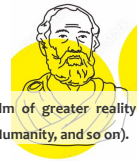
An aristocratic man with plenty of money and a superb physique, Plato at one time won two prizes as a championship wrestler.

Actually, the man's real (and little known) name was Aristocles; Plato was just a nickname given to him by his friends, whose original connotation made reference to his broad shoulders.

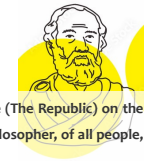
Plato became an enthusiastic and talented student of Socrates and wrote famous dialogues featuring his teacher verbally grappling with opponents.



Our wrestler believed in the pre-existence and immortality of the soul, holding that life is nothing more than the imprisonment of the soul in a body.



In addition to the physical world, there is a heavenly realm of greater reality consisting in Forms, Ideals, or Ideas (such as Equality, Justice, Humanity, and so on).



As his crowning achievement: He wrote a famous treatise (The Republic) on the ideal society, in which he expressed the thought that a philosopher, of all people, who should be king (big surprise!).

Aristotle: A long walk to the Golden Mean

Aristotle was Plato's best student. He went on to become the very well-paid tutor of Alexander the Great — probably the highest paid philosopher in history.

Aristotle started his own philosophical school when he was 50 years old.

Although he lived only ten more years, he produced nearly a thousand books and pamphlets, only a few of which have survived.

This great thinker was called a peripatetic philosopher (peripateo = "to walk around") because he liked to lecture to his students while taking a walk.

Another group of philosophers were called stoics because they preferred sitting around on porches (stoa) when they shot the breeze.

A key theme in Aristotle's thought is that happiness is the goal of life. Aristotle was a good deal less other-worldly than Plato.

He voluntarily went into exile from Athens when conditions became a bit politically dangerous for him, in his words, "lest Athens sin twice against philosophy."

The founder of logical theory, Aristotle believed that the greatest human endeavor is the use of reason in theoretical activity.

One of his best known ideas was his conception of "The Golden Mean" — "avoid extremes," the counsel of moderation in all things.